Lourdes Miquel and Neus Sans

Is that you, María?



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Title: *Is that you, María?*

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In this story you will meet the following characters:

Lola Lago: she runs a detective agency in Madrid. She has a new case to solve.

Paco: he works with Lola Lago. He is her business partner and friend.

Miguel: he is Lola's other business partner. All three of them work as detectives.

Margarita: she is Lola, Paco and Miguel's secretary.

Carmela: she is an old friend and neighbour of Lola's.

Doña Elvira: she is the concierge of a building in Madrid's Plaza de la Paja.

Inspector Gil: he is a police inspector in Madrid. He does not like women detectives.

Ramona: she is a nurse at La Paz Hospital in Madrid.

Doña Lupe: she lives in Plaza de la Paja and has been the victim of a burglary.

Néstor Requena: he is Doña Lupe's grandson and wants to find out who broke into his grandmother's home and robbed her.

María: she is Doña Lupe's niece... or is she?

1

I put down the phone. I was tired and my legs hurt. It had been a hard day at the office. It was eleven o'clock and I still had not had dinner. As soon as I got home, Valentina had rung me. She is a friend who always calls at night to tell me about her problems. And all I wanted was to eat something, watch a silly programme on television and go to bed. Television is always full of detective stories that are nothing like the ones in our office. Stories about tall, handsome detectives and rich people with rich people's problems. At our office, none of us is tall or handsome. Not Paco, not Miguel and not me. And our clients are neither film stars nor millionaires.

I went into the kitchen and looked in the fridge. It was almost empty. I made myself a hard-boiled egg and a salad. I took a beer and two apples and carried everything into the sitting room. I was not very hungry. More than anything, I wanted the ice-cold beer. That day, 15 July, it was very hot in Madrid[1].

I switched on the television. There was a film about tall, fair-haired and brave detectives who were nothing like Paco or Miguel, my dear partners. Or me.

2

It was still very hot, terribly hot. I got up to open the balcony doors and see whether there was any breeze. On the balcony, I looked at the plants. I had to water them. They were completely dry.

Down below, the street was silent. There are hardly any cars in the square where I live, the Plaza de la Paja in old Madrid, and very few people at night. That night, a couple were standing under a street lamp. I watched them for a moment.

“A couple saying goodbye,” I thought. Then I sat down on the sofa again.

After a while, I heard voices in the street. Nervous voices. Someone shouted, “No!” I went back out onto the balcony. The couple were still down there, but they no longer looked like a happy couple saying goodbye. She was crying. He was looking away and saying nothing. Then she said something. I could not hear what it was, but she seemed angry. I felt a little ashamed to be standing there, watching and listening.

“An occupational habit,” I thought, looking for an excuse.

Then the young woman ran off. He started to follow her, but changed his mind and stopped. I could no longer see the young woman. He went into the building opposite my home, number 10.

Everything was quiet again and I decided to go to bed. I knew I would not fall asleep at once. That always happens when I am very tired. I looked for a book: a crime novel with murderers and detectives who are nothing like the ones in our agency.

3

After brushing my teeth, I remembered my poor plants. I had to water them. There was no way round it. I went out onto the balcony again. I looked at the building opposite, where the young man had gone in. I thought it was silly to stand there thinking about people I did not know. The building opposite was dark. But suddenly a light on the third floor came on. I saw the shadow of a man. He was moving quickly. Then the light went off again.

I could not stop watching. I thought it was him.

A few minutes later, the man came out into the street again. I watched him closely, like a zoologist. He looked very nervous. He was walking very fast. He did not look like a worried lover, but like someone doing something dangerous or illegal... That was what my detective's instinct told me.

"Tomorrow I'll speak to the concierge," I thought.

At half past twelve, I finally went to bed with a Raymond Chandler novel[2]...

4

"Oh! The plants!" I suddenly thought, already in bed. "Those interesting neighbours have made me forget the geraniums again..." So it was back to the balcony once more.

While I was watering them, the young woman from earlier returned. I recognised her immediately. She went into the building. The lights came on on the third floor and soon went off again. Then the young woman came out with two suitcases and a bag. She was in a hurry. When she reached the street, she dropped her handbag. She picked it up and walked quickly towards Calle Segovia[3].



I stood there watching. Something was shining on the ground. Something had fallen out of the handbag. What should I do? I got dressed and went downstairs to look for it.

In front of the building, I found a bunch of keys. None of the keys opened the door.

Then I went to bed. I was very tired. It was already quarter past one.

5

I got up at eleven. It was Sunday. I bought *El País*[4] and sat at a café terrace in the Plaza de la Paja. On Sunday mornings, I love sitting outside and reading the paper in peace. I ordered a white coffee[5] and began to look through the Sunday supplement[6]. Wonderful! A whole Sunday to... to do nothing, absolutely nothing.

After a while, an ambulance drove into the square. It stopped in front of number 10, the same building as the night before. A group of neighbours came out and stood by the entrance. They all looked serious and spoke quietly. A few minutes later, the ambulance crew carried an old woman out on a stretcher. She looked very seriously ill. I left my coffee and moved closer. In the middle of the group, a very nervous woman of about sixty was explaining something to the others. She was the concierge. She kept repeating, “My God! What a terrible thing!” I moved even closer so that I could hear everything. Someone had broken into the old woman’s flat, Doña Lupe’s, assaulted her and stolen from her.

“I bring her the paper every Sunday, but today no one opened the door. I thought it was very strange. As I have a key, I went inside. And there she was, the poor woman, on the floor, covered in blood. What a fright I had! At first I thought she was dead... My God! What a terrible thing!” explained Doña Elvira, the concierge.

“Doña Elvira, what about the niece? Doesn’t Doña Lupe live with a niece?” one of the neighbours asked.

“I don’t know where she can be... I didn’t see her yesterday... She travels so much... She’s an air hostess or something like that. Oh, my God! What a terrible thing!” said the concierge.

In fact, she was delighted to be the centre of attention. You could see it.

6

Soon afterwards, two police officers arrived: Inspector Lucas Gil and a man called Peña. I knew them only by sight, but I greeted them like old friends. It is a good way to get information.

“Listen, I’d like to speak to you later,” I said to Gil. “I live over there, opposite, you know. Last night, I saw several things from my balcony that might be connected with all this.”

Gil and Peña looked at me suspiciously. I know that look well. Most Spanish police officers look at women detectives like that. They treat us like little girls playing at being grown-ups. In the end, they agreed to have a coffee with me.

“I’ll be waiting for you over there, at the terrace opposite. Don’t forget, all right?”

“How could we forget?”

“See you in a moment.”

“See you.”

The concierge carried on talking. Doña Lupe lived on the third floor, in the flat on the right. Exactly where all the strange coming and going had taken place the night before.

“You knew it, Lola, you knew it...” I said to myself.

7

Gil ordered a *carajillo*[7], and Peña a small glass of draught beer[8]. I began to tell them what had happened the night before.

"What did he look like?" Gil asked.

"I don't know... It was very dark. He did not seem very tall, and he was wearing fairly smart clothes, I think... Oh, yes, and he had a beard."

"And her?" Peña asked, looking at me as if I were the thief.

"Long hair, slim... I don't know, it's difficult to say. My flat is on the fourth floor, you know. And I'm a little short-sighted."

"It could be the niece..." Gil remarked.

"Possibly," I replied. "I thought of that too."

"If you remember anything else, ring the police station."

"Of course."

Gil and Peña stood up to leave. They did not like women detectives. It was obvious.

"I'd like to know how it all ends..." I said.

"Listen, young lady, this is a job for the police..."

"I know, I know... I'm only curious."

"Then read about it in the paper, young lady."

"All right, all right..."

I hate being called "young lady", but I said nothing. A private detective is better off not having trouble with the police.

8

After lunch, I tried to have a siesta[9] on the sofa. It was terribly hot. I could not stop thinking about what had happened that morning. I wanted to know more. But what could I do?

I decided to ring Paco, one of my partners. He usually stays at home on Sundays. I wanted to tell him everything and find out what he thought.

“Hello...?” said a sleepy voice.

“It’s me, Lola. What are you doing?”

“Sleeping... I mean, I was asleep. In this heat...”

“Sorry...”

“It’s all right... You’re the third person to ring in the last half-hour.”

“Listen, I’m sorry...”

“All right, it doesn’t matter. What did you want?”

I told him everything: what had happened the night before, the concierge’s explanation and my conversation with the police officers.

“I know that Gil. Don’t you remember? We had to work with him on the Treviño case,” said Paco.

“The Treviño case?”

“Yes, two years ago. The stolen jewellery in Alicante[10].”

“Oh, yes, now I remember.”

“He doesn’t like private detectives at all.”

“I’d already noticed.”

“Right, now tell me: why are you waking me up to tell me all this? What has this case got to do with us?”

“Nothing. I had to tell someone.”

“Lola, you know my theory: if there isn’t a paying client...”

“Yes, of course.”

“We’re not working as a hobby[11]!”

“Yes, you’re right.”

“Changing the subject, remember that Mr Serrano is coming to the office tomorrow. He’s the one whose business partner ran off with the ‘dough’[12].”

“What time?”

“About ten.”

“Great.”

“What are you doing this afternoon?”

“I’ve no idea. Dying of heat.”

“And then?”

“Nothing.”

“Have a siesta, like me. You’ll see: then all your friends will start ringing you.”

“Very funny!”

“See you tomorrow, young lady.”

“Don’t call me young lady.”

“All right, young lady.”

“Grrrrr[13]...”

9

At nine o’clock on Monday morning, I left home. I had slept badly and did not feel like going to the office. It was already very hot at that hour. On the other side of the square, I saw Doña Elvira, the concierge of number 10. Of course, I went over to speak to her.

“Doña Elvira... excuse me...” I began.

“Good morning. How can I help you?” she replied, ready to answer all my questions.

“I live over there, opposite, and... I’m a journalist, you know.”

“A journalist? Really? On television?”

“No, I work for a magazine.”

I preferred not to tell the truth. Perhaps Doña Elvira did not like private detectives either.

“And which magazine do you work for?” she asked.

“Well... a new one. You probably don’t know it yet. It’s called *This Week*. I wanted to find out what happened on the third floor...”

“Oh, it was terrible. Poor Doña Lupe is in a very serious condition, very serious... She’s in a coma at La Paz Hospital[14]. And she’s very old, poor thing. She must be about eighty-five.”

“What exactly happened?”

“You see... For many years, I’ve brought Doña Lupe the paper every Sunday. She can’t read any more because she can hardly see. When María is at home, she reads the paper to her. Otherwise, I explain what I’ve understood. Oh, the things they print in the papers: nothing but bad news and wars...”

“And what happened next?”

“Yesterday I went upstairs, as I do every Sunday. I rang once, then again, but nothing: she didn’t open the door. Naturally, I began to worry. She never goes out, you know. In the end, I went to fetch the key. I have a key to the flat.”

“And you opened it...”

“Exactly. My God! What a fright I had! She was lying there on the floor, poor thing. At first I thought she was dead. I called an ambulance and the police immediately.”

“Was anything stolen?”

“I’ve already told the police: Doña Lupe is very rich, extremely rich. Her husband, Don Anastasio, rest his soul[15], lived in Cuba for several years. He made a great deal of money there. They also sold some land on the coast, in Alicante, I think. They received millions for it, many millions.”

“Do you think she kept money at home?”

“Money, I don’t know; jewellery, yes. Very valuable jewellery. She showed it to me once. It was magnificent!”

“And has the jewellery disappeared?”

“My dear, I don’t know. Those police officers who came...”

“Yes, I know them.”

“They wouldn’t tell me anything. Nothing at all. Not even me, although I’m almost one of the family.”

“I heard that Doña Lupe lived with a niece.”

“Yes, with that one...”

“What is the niece’s name?”

“María, María Requena. Do you know her?”

“No, not at all.”

“No, it’s because you said you live opposite... She’s a young woman, how can I put it? A little strange. It’s probably because of the accident, I suppose...”

“What accident?”

“She had a very serious car accident, apparently. Just before she came to live with Doña Lupe.”

“And you say María is Doña Lupe’s niece?”

“Yes. Actually, she’s the daughter of one of Doña Lupe’s nephews, who also lived in Cuba. María was born in Cuba. Then they moved to the United States. María lived in America until last year, when she came to Spain. That’s when she had the accident. I think she also spent three months at La Paz Hospital.”

“And now?”

“That’s the strange thing. I’ve no idea where she is. I saw her on Saturday morning, but not since then...”

“Do you know what she does?”

“I think she’s a hostess, but not one who flies. She works at trade fairs, conferences and that sort of thing.”

“I see... And what does she look like?”

“Pretty... yes, quite pretty. Tall, slim... But very quiet. She never talks to me. And people who don’t like talking... I don’t know, I don’t take to them. But Doña Lupe was happy to have her here. Poor thing, she’s so lonely...”

“Doesn’t she have any children?”

“Yes, she has a son and a grandson, Néstor. They live in Italy and never come here. There were problems in the family. Doña Lupe’s son wanted to be an architect and did not want to look after the family business. So Don Anastasio disinherited him.”

Doña Lupe told me that herself. Now the police are trying to find them.

I was silent for a moment, thinking.

“Will you write something in your magazine? Don’t use my name, will you?” she said.

“No, of course not. I haven’t got enough information yet. I’ll come back in a few days to see whether there’s any news, all right?”

“Whenever you like. I’m always here.”

“Thank you very much.”

I had been talking to Doña Elvira for a long time. I was going to be late for the office. As usual!

10

“Morning,” I said as I went in.

“Good morning,” replied Margarita, without stopping painting her nails. “Miguel is waiting for you. I think he’s ringing you at home right now.”

Margarita, our secretary, is very nice, but her main job, apart from painting her nails, is to ring her boyfriend Tony every half-hour. To Margarita, Tony is Robert Redford himself, except that he is a Robert Redford who is only a metre and a half tall. Margarita makes thousands of spelling mistakes in letters to clients and her desk looks like a perfume shop. There is also a huge photograph on it: Tony and Margarita holding hands in a park.

That day, Margarita was in a bad mood. The day before, Tony had not taken her to the cinema. Miguel was in a bad mood too.

“At last! It’s about time!”

“It’s only quarter past ten... Where’s Paco?”

“He hasn’t arrived yet either. And Mr Serrano could be here any minute!”

“Well, the two of us are here, aren’t we?” I replied. “How was your weekend?”

“Terrible.”

“Why?”

“I felt very, very ill. Friday night’s dinner disagreed with me and...”

“Weren’t you going out on Friday with an old friend from university?”

“Yes.”

“And how was it?”

“It was the seafood.”

“What?”

“The clams disagreed with me.”

“Yes, of course, seafood...”

Whenever Miguel goes out with a woman, something always hurts or something upsets his stomach.

“And you?” he asked.

“So-so. Nothing special.”

“Oh, my stomach!”

“Why don’t you send Feliciano to the chemist’s?”

I asked without much interest because I was already used to Miguel’s illnesses.

“Feliciano? He went out for a coffee at nine and he hasn’t come back yet.”

Feliciano also works in our detective agency. Or at least that is what he says. He is a sort of motorbike courier[16], a general assistant. Of course, that is when you can find him. And you can almost never find him. He spends hours away from the office and loses important documents that he is meant to deliver. He is always eating enormous sandwiches filled with sardines, tuna or anchovies[17]. Feliciano is nineteen. He is very thin, very pale and slightly cross-eyed. Everyone at the agency thinks that...

...he is secretly in love with Margarita. He thinks no one knows. When he talks to Margarita, he turns as red as a tomato and drops his sandwich. Oh, I almost forgot: Feliciano writes poetry, long love poems.

I was beginning to think it was a terrible Monday too when Paco, my other partner, arrived. Paco is plump and always cheerful. That Monday, he could not understand why we all gave him dark looks when he said:

“Good morning, everyone! What a lovely day! Don’t you think so? Is something wrong?”

No one replied.

11

Three days later, on Thursday, I was still thinking about the strange case of Doña Lupe and what had happened on Sunday night.

That afternoon, on my way home, I decided to visit the concierge, Doña Elvira, again. She told me that Doña Lupe was already a little better.

“I visited her yesterday,” she said. “The doctors say she’ll be able to come home in a few days.”

“Did she see anything on Sunday?”

“She says she heard noises and got up. She went towards the sitting room. After that, all she remembers is the blow to her head.”

“So she didn’t see anything or anyone.”

“Well, the poor woman can hardly see.”

“Oh, yes, of course.”

12

I met Carmela in the entrance to my building. Carmela is my neighbour and friend. She is sixty years old and weighs ninety kilos. She is always heavily made-up and laughs like a child. When she was young, she was a performer, a dancer in a cabaret. She says she has had eighteen boyfriends and three husbands. To me, she is like one of the family.

Carmela is an excellent cook and sometimes brings me some soup or invites me to dinner. She says I do not look after myself, I work too much and I am going to make myself ill.

"Lola! How are you, beautiful? I haven't seen you for days. Oh, you do look terrible!"

"Hello, Carmela."

"Guess what I've made for dinner today. Basque-style hake[18]. A whole hake! Why don't you come up later?"

"Oh, yes. My fridge is like the Sahara Desert."

I enjoy having dinner with Carmela. She tells me old stories about the theatre and her love affairs. As well as being an excellent cook, Carmela is a very intelligent woman. When I have a difficult case, I tell her about it. She always gives me good advice. She would make a great detective. I often tell her so.

After dinner, we had a glass of *orujo*[19] from Carmela's home village. I told her Doña Lupe's story. Carmela listened carefully.

"I've got an idea," she said. "Why don't you go to La Paz Hospital? I have a very good friend who works there as a nurse. You can see the old lady and ask about María, the niece. Hospitals know a lot about people."

"A very good idea. Carmela, the hake was delicious!"

"I've got homemade cannelloni for tomorrow."

"Cannelloni make you fat, Carmela."

“Oh, come on... You’re getting thinner every day!”

Neither my scales nor I agreed with Carmela. The next day, I was going to eat nothing but salad and fruit. I had eaten too much hake.

13

On Tuesday, I left home early, at eight o’clock. Eight is very early for me[20]. There was no coffee at home, so I went to the café on the corner for breakfast. I often have breakfast there.

“A white coffee?” asked Luís, the owner.

“Thank you, Luís, and a packet of ‘Habanos’[21].”

“Are you smoking again, Miss Lola? Didn’t you give up?”

“Yes, Luís, yes. Unfortunately, I’ve started again. It’s my nerves.”

“But it’s very bad for you...”

“I know, I know.”

A man of about thirty-five was standing at the bar beside me. Dark-haired, strong, well dressed... Perhaps more interesting than handsome. He was certainly not a regular customer. I decided to ask him for a light.

“I’m sorry, I don’t smoke,” he replied with a smile.

“Good for you!” I said, blushing a little.

“Here’s a box of matches, Miss Lola,” said Luís, who had been listening to our conversation.

Then the attractive new customer asked Luís for some change for the telephone. He took the coins, dialled a number and began to speak.

“Good morning. I’d like to speak to Dr Sánchez Mata.”

He waited for a moment, then said:

“Good morning, Doctor. This is Néstor Requena. Yes, that’s right, Mrs Requena’s grandson.”

I listened without missing a word and grew more and more nervous. What a coincidence! And what luck!

"Yes, yes, of course, all right. I'll come to the hospital at once," Néstor said to the doctor.

I did not know what to do. Should I speak to him? I did not think for long. It was now or never. I took one of my business cards out of my handbag and, when he put down the phone, I said:

"Excuse me, you're Néstor Requena, aren't you?"

"Yes."

"I know what happened to your grandmother, and I also know several facts that the police don't. I think I can help you."

He looked very surprised. I gave him my card. He looked at it and said:

"A private detective! I didn't know there were women detectives..."

"There aren't many of us."

"I hadn't thought of hiring a detective. The police..."

"Yes, of course," I said. "But if you change your mind, the telephone number is on the card."

He was astonished. I decided that he was even more handsome with that surprised expression.

I finished my coffee, shook his hand and went out into the street.

"Not bad, Miss Marlowe[22]," I said to myself.

14

I took a taxi in Calle Segovia. I usually get about on my scooter, my old Vespa. But it had been out of action since Thursday.

At the hospital, I asked for Carmela's friend. Five minutes later, a nurse arrived. She was short and had red hair. She looked very friendly.

“Hello, I’m Ramona. Carmela has told me a lot about you. Do you want to see Doña Lupe straight away, or shall we have a coffee first?”

“Good idea. Coffee first.”

We began to talk in the hospital cafeteria.

“Yes, I remember María Requena. It was a terrible accident. Two cars collided on the road to Burgos[23]. The other young woman...”

“What other young woman?” I asked.

“There were two of them: two cars and two young women, about the same age. The other young woman, Jacinta, was in a worse condition. They were in the same room, you know. Jacinta died. She had a very serious skull fracture. I don’t know much more because I usually worked in gynaecology then. I only looked after them for two or three days while I was covering for someone.”

“Do you know another nurse who...?”

“No, I don’t think so. There are lots of new nurses on that ward now. There is one male nurse, Jenaro. But he hasn’t been here for several days. Perhaps he’s ill or on holiday. We can also look at the medical records in the archive. Would you like to?”

“Yes, why not?”

We finished our coffee and went to the archive.

“Did anyone visit María in hospital?”

“I don’t know, I can’t remember... We see so many people! But I don’t think she had any family or anyone like that.”

Outside the doors of several offices, Ramona said:

“Wait here for a moment. I’ll be right back.”

“All right.”

Ten minutes later, she came out looking worried.

“Something very strange has happened.”

“What?”

“Her medical records aren’t there. Nothing, absolutely nothing about María Requena...”

“And the other young woman’s records?” I asked, without knowing why.

“I don’t know. Are you interested in her too?”

“Perhaps.”

“I’ll check,” she said, and went away again.

She came back almost at once.

“This is even stranger. There’s nothing there either. It’s unbelievable!”

“Documents sometimes get lost,” I said, thinking of Feliciano, the boy from my agency.

“Not here. It never happens. And what’s more, both young women’s records are missing! It’s very suspicious.”

We were silent, lost in thought.

“Shall we go and see the grandmother now?” Ramona suggested.

“Let’s go.”

15

When we entered room 201, Doña Lupe asked:

“Is that you, María?”

“No, it’s me, Ramona. María hasn’t come yet. But she’ll be here soon, you’ll see,” said Ramona, taking her hand.

Doña Lupe closed her eyes and fell asleep. In that white room, in that white bed, she seemed tiny, tiny and very, very old. I felt sorry for her.

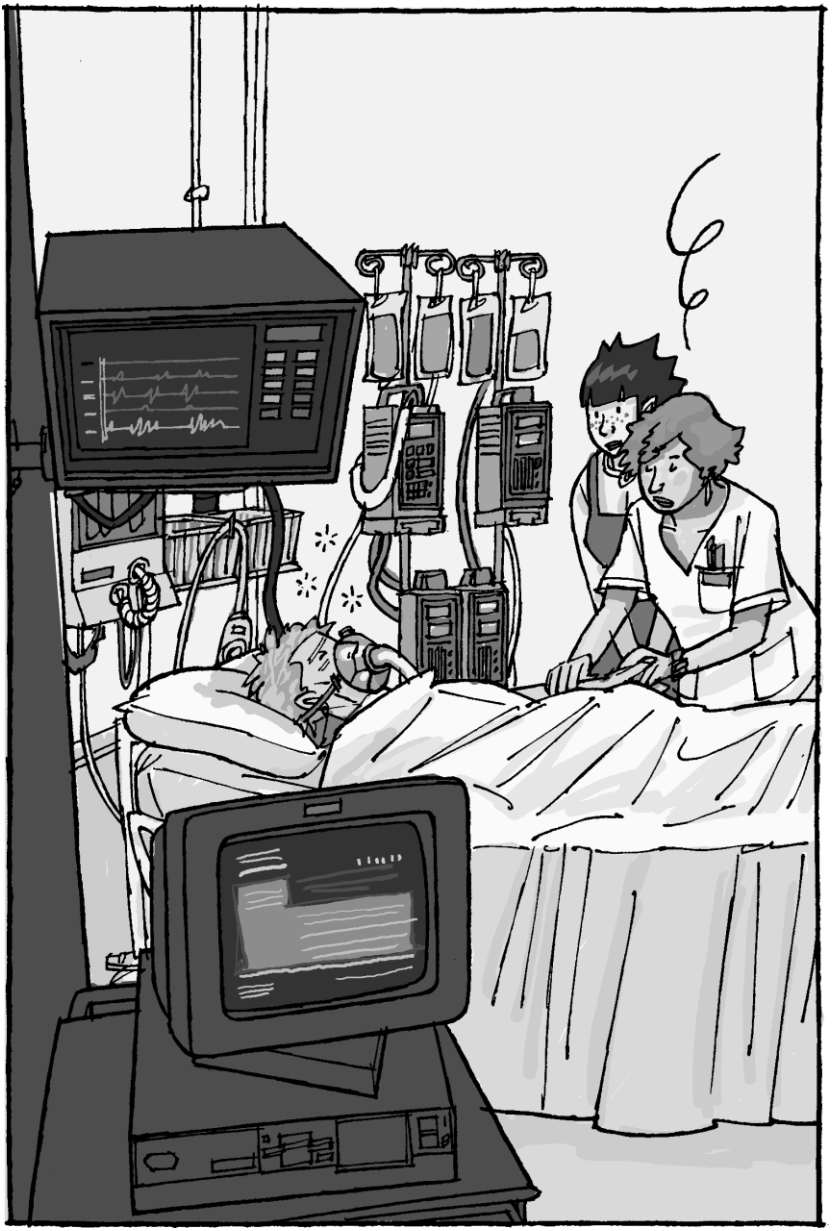
“I don’t know... She’s in quite a bad way. Perhaps you could come back another day to speak to her? She’s very tired today.”

“Yes, you’re right. Thank you for everything, Ramona.”

“That’s all right. Carmela’s friends are my friends,” she said.

I left the hospital and took a taxi to the office.

“38 Calle Alcalá, near Sevilla Metro station.”



16

When I arrived, Margarita was on the telephone to her boyfriend.

“Hold on a moment, darling. Lola, there’s a message for you.”

“Yes? Who from?”

“Someone called Néstor rang.”

“Hurray! Néstor!”

Feliciano gave me a frightened look and dropped his anchovy sandwich on the carpet.

“Yes, darling. Yes, sweetheart, just a second,” Margarita said into the telephone. “He said he’ll come at half past one.”

“Néstor what?” I asked, to be completely sure.

“Néstor Reteña. Wait... I wrote it down somewhere...”

“It should be Requena...”

“Well, Requeña or Retena, or something like that.”

“Thank you, dear,” I said.

“Yes, sweetheart, what were you saying?”

Margarita carried on talking on the telephone. Feliciano was still looking at her sadly.

17

“Paco, I think we’ve got a new client,” I explained.

Paco was reading comics peacefully in his office.

“Fantastic! We need one. Who is it?”

“Néstor Requena. Do you remember what I told you on Sunday?”

“More or less. I was having a siesta at the time.”

“He’s the grandson of my neighbour, Doña Lupe.”

“Lola... you’re incredible!” said Paco, laughing.

“Fantastic, isn’t it?”

“Yes, young lady, yes.”

“He’ll be here at half past one.”

18

At exactly half past one, Néstor entered the agency. Unusually, Margarita got up from her chair and showed him into my office. I am sure she thought, “He’s almost as handsome as my Tony.”

I quickly explained everything to him, including what I had found out at the hospital.

“So you’re already working,” he said.

“More or less. It’s almost a sport for me.”

“Now you’ll be working for me. I want to know what happened. Everything is a bit strange. My grandmother had some very valuable jewellery. Two boxes: one contained the real jewels and the other contained identical copies. Exact reproductions. It was very difficult to see the difference. But...”

“But what?”

“Only the real jewels were taken. And they were not easy to find. I spoke to my grandmother and she explained everything. The thief knew all about them. It is someone who knows her very well.”

“And María has disappeared...” I said. “What do the police say?”

“I spoke to someone called Gil.”

“And?”

“I don’t know... I don’t like him. I don’t trust him. That’s why I came.”

“I understand. We charge twenty thousand pesetas a day, plus expenses.”

“That doesn’t matter.”

“It matters to me. Excellent. I’ll ring you when I find something out.”

“All right. I’m staying with some friends. Write this down: 3181802.”

“See you soon.”

“Goodbye.”

“Wait a moment. I’d like to see your grandmother’s flat. Have you got the keys?”

“Yes, but I’ll ask my grandmother for permission first.”

“All right. Will you ring me later?”

“Yes. One more thing: perhaps we could call each other by our first names[24]?”

“I don’t mind.”

“See you, Lola.”

“See you.”

19

I went out to have a sandwich. Paco was having lunch at his parents’ house and Miguel had stomach ache. I ate alone. I hate eating alone, so I had finished in fifteen minutes. I drank a *cortado*[25] in a café and went back to the office. The telephone was ringing. I ran inside.

“Hello?”

“Lola, it’s Ramona, Carmela’s friend.”

“Hello, Ramona. Go on.”

“I’m ringing because I kept looking and found something: Jacinta’s address, the other young woman. Do you want it?”

“Yes. It’s worth going there to see whether anyone remembers anything.”

“Write it down: 11 Calle Santa Bárbara, first floor, flat D. ‘D’ for Denmark.”

“Thank you, dear.”

“You’re welcome. Good luck! And give my regards to Carmela.”

20

The telephone rang again. It was Néstor.

“I’ve spoken to my grandmother. She agrees. When shall we look at the flat?”

“Whenever you like.”

“I’ve got nothing to do this afternoon...”

“Then let’s go now. Where shall we meet?”

“Outside the entrance to the building?”

“All right. See you there.”

The traffic in the centre was terrible. And without my scooter... I had to take a taxi! It took me half an hour to get there.

“Sorry. The traffic is dreadful today.”

“Don’t worry. I’ve only just arrived too.”

Néstor was wearing a grey shirt. I thought it was the same colour as his eyes.

We went into the flat. It was dark. There were lots of old pieces of furniture, beautiful rugs and lovely paintings. There was a piano in the sitting room.

“I’d like to see María’s room,” I said.

“I think it’s at the end. But I’m not sure: I haven’t been here for years.”

In María’s room, there were some clothes, all expensive, several books, mostly about the theatre, and not much else. The bed had not been made.

I opened the drawers in the chest of drawers. Lots of underwear. Finally, in the bottom drawer, we found some papers. We began to look through them. There was a photograph of a young woman in a swimming costume on a beach.

“Is that María?”

“I don’t know. I only saw her once, when we were children. We haven’t had any contact in recent years.”

“I see.”

There was also a postcard signed “Jenaro”. It had been sent from Oviedo[26]. The message was strange: “She was the one in the photograph.” I showed it to Néstor.

“Strange, isn’t it?”

“Yes, it isn’t an ordinary postcard...”

We left the room and walked round the flat once more: nothing interesting, a typical rich grandmother’s flat.

“Jenaro, Jenaro... Where have I heard that name in the last few days?” I said.

“I only knew one Jenaro. Actually, two. A father and son. My grandfather had a secretary called Jenaro, Jenaro Llamas. But there were problems with him. He drank a lot and my grandfather sacked him. I used to play with his son, Jeno. He was my best friend. I think he lives in Asturias now.”

“The postcard is from Asturias. What a coincidence!”

“Yes...”

“I know!”

“What?”

“Now I know who told me about Jenaro! At the hospital. The male nurse who looked after María is called Jenaro.”

“Perhaps it’s another coincidence.”

“You know, Néstor, in my profession, coincidences don’t exist...”

21

We both went out, deep in thought. In the street, I asked:

“Have you got anything to do?”

“No. Why?”

“I want to see one more flat, the one where Jacinta lived.”

“Jacinta?”

“The young woman who shared María’s hospital room.”

“Why?”

“I don’t know yet.”

“All right, I’ll come with you.”

“Shall we take a taxi?”

“No, I came on a motorbike. A friend lent it to me.”

“Fantastic. I love riding on motorbikes.”

“It’s over there.”

The motorbike was wonderful.

“I’m glad I didn’t come on my old Vespa!” I thought.

22

We reached Calle Santa Bárbara. We rang the bell, but no one answered. Suddenly, something caught my attention: the lock. It was very unusual. Then came a moment of feminine intuition and I began searching in my handbag. One of the keys María had lost on Sunday was also very unusual. Without saying anything, I tried it. The door opened. Néstor stared at me with his mouth open.

“But, but...”

“I’ll explain later. Let’s go upstairs now.”

On the first floor, outside flat D, we rang again. No one answered. I tried another key and the door of the flat opened too. In the hall, a naked young man who had just come out of the shower was staring at us in alarm.

“What’s going on? What do you want? Who are you?”

He ran into the bathroom and came back with a towel round his waist.

“Calm down, calm down... Nothing has happened. It must be a mistake. Doesn’t a young woman called Jacinta live here?” I asked calmly.

Néstor looked more and more surprised.

“No, no young woman lives here, and you can’t...”

“I’m really sorry. I thought a friend of mine lived here and, since the keys opened the doors...”

“Who are you looking for? A young woman used to live here...”

“Yes, we’re looking for a young woman.”

“Wait a moment. I rented this flat about a year ago. Some of the young woman’s things were still here. I’ve still got them.”

He went away and came back a few minutes later.

“Here they are.”

There was some bed linen, a bundle of letters and some documents. The letters were addressed to Jacinta Romero Díaz. Many had the same signature: “Jenaro”. There was also a passport. Occupation: actress.

“A few too many coincidences, don’t you think?”

“Yes, far too many.”

23

We went into a bar. We needed something strong to drink.

“A brandy for me.”

“The same for me,” we said to the waiter.

We began to look through the papers more calmly. There were also several photographs of a young woman.

“This must be Jacinta.”

“Let me see. Let me see that photograph. I’ve seen that man before... But I can’t remember where... My God! What a mess!”

Néstor was silent, thinking. After a while, he said:

“Listen, there’s one thing I don’t understand. Where did you find the keys to this flat?”

“That’s the strangest thing: María had them. She dropped them outside her home on Sunday. I picked them up.”

“Why did María have the keys to Jacinta’s flat when Jacinta died a year ago?”

“I’ve no idea.”

We said goodbye and I went back to the office. I wanted to think. I think better when there is no one in the office. But I was too tired to think. I remembered Carmela’s cannelloni.

“I’ll start my diet tomorrow,” I thought. “Tomorrow, only fruit and salad.”

24

Carmela’s cannelloni were delicious. She told me about her love affair with an Irish sea captain and we laughed for a long time. Then I went home. It was still hot, so I opened the balcony doors. I looked towards number 10. It had become a habit. Someone was going in. Someone? It was María! I put on my shoes and ran downstairs. I had to find her, follow her or speak to her... By the time I reached the street, she had already gone inside. I decided to wait. Half an hour later, the door opened and she came out. She was carrying a bag.

“Is that you, María?” I asked.

She jumped, looked at me and said nothing.

“Who are you? What do you want?” she asked after a moment.

“Are you María Requena?” I asked again.

“Why do you want to know?” she replied.

At that moment, she took a small gun out of her handbag.

“Don’t follow me... Don’t follow me or I’ll shoot!” she shouted.

She ran towards Calle Segovia. There was nothing I could do. I went home. It was too late to ring Néstor or Paco... In any case, it would not have helped. She had got away.

“She’s taller than she looks in the photograph,” I thought. And I fell asleep on the sofa.

25

In the morning, I rang Inspector Gil. I told him about María. Nothing else.

“We’re looking for her,” he said.

“It’s all rather strange, don’t you think?”

“Strange? Why? She took the jewellery. That’s all.”

“Gil, she’s Doña Lupe’s niece... The grandson, Néstor Requena, told me that María is the only heir named in the will. Doña Lupe and her husband disinherited their son.”

“You know a lot...”

“It’s my case too.”

“Really? Since when?”

“Since yesterday. I’m working for Mr Requena, Doña Lupe’s grandson.”

“Very interesting...” he said sarcastically. “But don’t forget that you can’t hide anything from the police, all right?”

“No, of course not,” I replied like a good little girl.

An unpleasant conversation with one of the most unpleasant police officers in Madrid.

26

At midday, the garage rang: my Vespa had been repaired. I took a taxi to collect it. At Plaza de Cibeles[27], the taxi stopped at a red light. A woman was crossing the street: María! Her again! It was my lucky day.

“Please let me out here.”

“One hundred and eighty.”

“Here you are. Keep the change.”

I got out of the taxi and began to follow her. I kept my distance so that she would not see me.

She sat down at a table outside Café Gijón. She looked at her watch: she was waiting for someone. I went into a phone box and rang the office.

I could see her clearly from the phone box. The office line was engaged: Margarita was certainly talking to Tony. At last, someone answered.

“Margarita, is Miguel there? Miguel or Paco...”

“Yes, who’s speaking?”

“It’s me, Lola. Quickly...”

“I’ll put you through, I’ll put you through...”

“Hello?” answered Miguel.

“Miguelito, come at once. I’m in the phone box opposite the ‘Gijón’[28]. I need you.”

“Listen, I was just leaving for the dentist’s and...”

“Miguel, I’m telling you that I need one of you. You or Paco. Both of you, if possible.”

“All right, all right... But what has happened?”

“Come here and I’ll explain.”

27

Ten minutes later, Paco and Miguel arrived without hurrying. I had been waiting for them very impatiently. I explained the situation. Then I said:

“Sit over there, beside her. She knows me.”

“All right, young lady.”

“Grrr... Hurry up.”

At that moment, a man arrived, a bearded man. I recognised him: I had seen him in a photograph and on Sunday night. I waited in the phone box. Five minutes later, Paco came over to me.

“Lola, I think you’ve confused the two women. It isn’t her. The bearded man calls her Jacinta, not María...”

“Jacinta! Are you sure?”

“Yes. He told her that he was leaving Madrid, and she said she didn’t want to go with him. I don’t know, but I don’t think she is...”

“Paco, now I understand everything. I’m going to ring Gil at the police station. They must come at once.”

“I don’t understand anything,” said Paco.

“That doesn’t matter. We haven’t got time. It would take too long to explain... Watch them. Don’t let them leave. I’ll ring the police.”

“Listen, they’re paying. They’re leaving. What do we do?”

“Go, quickly, follow them. I’ll ring Gil.”

Luckily, the waiter took a long time to bring the bill. I had time to speak to Gil and explain part of the situation.

“We’re going to follow them. I’ll ring later,” I said.

“But listen, listen...”

“Later. They’re leaving!”

The young woman and the bearded man stood talking for another moment. Then they went in different directions.

“You two follow her and I’ll follow him. If anything happens, ring the office.”

The bearded man got into a taxi and I got into the next one.

“Follow that taxi, please.”

The classic line.

“Which one?”

“That one, that one. For heaven’s sake, that one!”

Too late. Too many cars on the Castellana, too many white taxis, all exactly alike. I gave the driver the office address.

Perhaps my partners had been luckier. At the office, Margarita was talking on the telephone.

“Margarita, I’m sorry, but I’m waiting for a very important call.”

“Goodbye, Tony, darling. I have to go. Yes, yes, sweetheart, I’ll ring you later.”

I poured myself a whisky. I was far too nervous. How awful to sit there, waiting and unable to do anything! At last, the telephone rang.

“It’s Paco. We’re at Atocha station[29]. She wants to catch a train. Platform 5.”

“I’ll be right there.”

As I left, I said to Margarita:

“Ring Inspector Gil. Tell him I’m at Atocha station. Platform 5.”

28

Paco and Miguel were at the station. About ten metres away, she was sitting on a bench: María? Jacinta? Soon afterwards, Gil, Peña and two other men arrived. We all went over to the young woman.

“Police,” said Gil, showing his badge.

“What’s going on?” she asked, frightened.

“Are you María Requena?” asked Gil.

He had not understood anything.

“Yes,” she replied.

“No,” I said. “This is Jacinta Romero Díaz. María Requena died a year ago at La Paz Hospital.”

Gil looked at me.

“What? How?”

“Arrest her, Inspector.”

“I didn’t want to, I didn’t want to... It was him, Jenaro... I...” she said very quietly.

29

At the police station, I spoke to Gil. Miguel and Paco were there too, listening carefully. Gil was not pleased. I knew far more than he did. In fact, by then I knew almost everything.

“A year ago, two young women had an accident. Two cars collided on the road to Burgos. Both women were taken to La Paz Hospital. Someone identified them there: María, the rich heiress, and Jacinta. María was in a critical condition. It was clear that she was going to die. It was easy to swap their identities. The two young women were the same age and looked alike... From that moment on, Jacinta became María Requena. The real María died, and Jacinta was to receive the inheritance.”

“Slow down, young lady... And who did all this?”

“I think it was Jenaro Llamas. He knew the Requena family very well. His father had worked for them. He also knew Jacinta very well. He was her boyfriend and...”

“And?”

“He worked as a nurse at La Paz Hospital.”

“Are you sure about all this?”

“Yes, I think that’s what happened.”

“And then?”

“Jacinta lived with Doña Lupe for a year. It was easy. The grandmother was almost blind, María had always lived in America and no one knew her... But Jenaro was tired of waiting.”

“Waiting for what?”

“For Doña Lupe to die, for the inheritance. Last Sunday, he decided to act. I don’t think she, María, or rather Jacinta, agreed with him.”

“And where is this Jenaro?”

“I don’t know. The young woman must know. Perhaps he’s in Asturias. Ask her.”



30

A few hours later, the police arrested Jenaro, known as Jeno, Néstor's childhood playmate, at Barajas Airport[30]. Doña Lupe's jewellery and a ticket to Mexico City were in his suitcase.

After leaving the police station, I went home. I was exhausted.

There was a message from Néstor on the answering machine: "Would you like to have dinner with me tonight? We need to talk. The police rang me, but... well, you'll explain everything better."

"The fruit-and-salad diet starts tomorrow," I thought, and sank into the bath.

31

Before going to dinner with Néstor, I stopped at the office for a moment. I wanted to see the others. Everyone except Miguel was still there.

"Wow! You look lovely! Where are you going tonight?" asked Paco.

Feliciano was looking at me almost as he looked at Margarita or his sandwiches.

"To dinner," I replied.

"With whom?"

"What's it got to do with you? With a client."

"Really?"

Suddenly, Margarita came in.

"Lola, I almost forgot: Néstor Requena rang. He wanted to have dinner with you tonight. I gave him your private number."

“Yes, yes, I know...”

“Oh! I see... The Requena case isn’t over yet, is it?”

“Ha, ha... Very funny! We have to prepare the bill, don’t we?”

“Yes, of course, of course...” he replied sarcastically.

“And Miguel?” I asked.

“In bed, with a stomach ache, toothache, backache... Who knows!”

“I see.”

“It’s a pity. He was meant to go out tonight with a friend, the woman of his life, according to him.”

“I see...” I said.

32

Néstor was waiting for me outside the office with an enormous bunch of roses.

“For the best detective in Madrid,” he said when he saw me.

“In Europe, in Europe... It’s not difficult. I’m almost the only one...”

He looked dazzling. Margarita, Feliciano and Paco were watching us from the office window.

33

The next day, Doña Lupe returned to her flat in the Plaza de la Paja. Néstor visited her with a large bunch of flowers. When he entered the room, his grandmother asked:

“Is that you, María?”

“No, Grandma, it’s me, Néstor.”

Doña Elvira, the concierge, told me about it, with a tear running down her cheek. Doña Elvira is sentimental. So am I. She also told me that Néstor might not return to Italy.

Now I have a dazzlingly handsome neighbour and a happy grandmother in the Plaza de la Paja.

NOTES

(1) A great deal of beer is drunk in Spain. It is usually served very cold. Madrid is often extremely hot in summer; the temperature sometimes reaches 40 °C.

(2) A famous American writer and author of crime novels.

(3) Calle Segovia is named after one of the most beautiful cities in central Spain.

(4) *El País* is Spain's best-selling daily newspaper. It has a progressive editorial position.

(5) Many Spaniards have breakfast away from home, in a café. Many have only coffee or coffee with milk, eating nothing or very little.

(6) As in many countries, Spanish newspapers come with one or more magazines on Sundays, containing articles, cultural information, puzzles, humour and other features.

(7) A *carajillo* is coffee with brandy or another alcoholic drink.

(8) A *caña* is a glass or small mug of draught beer.

(9) Some Spaniards sleep for a while after lunch, especially at weekends.

(10) Alicante is a popular tourist city on the Mediterranean coast.

(11) *Hobby* is an English word frequently used in Spanish.

(12) *Pasta* is a colloquial Spanish word for money.

(13) An onomatopoeic sound expressing discomfort or irritation.

(14) La Paz is one of the largest public hospitals in Madrid.

(15) “Rest his soul” is an expression used almost exclusively by older people when referring to someone who has died.

(16) Couriers are people who carry letters or parcels by motorbike from one place in a city to another. Today, many courier companies provide services to other businesses.

(17) Many sandwiches, known as *bocadillos*, are eaten in Spain: in the morning, as an afternoon snack, for the evening meal and even for lunch when there is little time. Bars offer many kinds, for example with cured meat, cheese, meat, omelette or tinned fish. Deep-fried squid sandwiches are typical of Madrid.

(18) Basque-style hake is a Basque fish dish. It is prepared in a sauce with clams, peas, asparagus, hard-boiled egg and parsley.

(19) *Orujo* is a strong spirit made in Galicia, a region in the north-west of the Iberian Peninsula.

(20) Eight o’clock is a normal time to get up in Spain. Many Spaniards get up earlier, however.

(21) Habanos is a brand of very strong, dark tobacco. Dark tobacco is also commonly smoked in Spain.

(22) Philip Marlowe is a famous detective created by Raymond Chandler.

(23) Burgos is a city in Castile, north of Madrid. It is of great historical and architectural interest and is especially famous for its Gothic cathedral.

(24) In Spain, young people normally address one another using the familiar *tú* form, even in professional relationships. Here, this is reflected in their decision to use first names.

(25) A *cortado* is coffee with a little milk. It is a very common way of drinking coffee in Spain.

(26) Oviedo is the capital of Asturias, a region in the north of the Iberian Peninsula.

(27) Cibeles is a square in the centre of Madrid.

(28) Café Gijón is a historic Madrid café, well known as a meeting place for intellectuals.

(29) Atocha is one of Madrid's railway stations. Trains heading south leave from there.

(30) Barajas is Madrid's airport.

DID YOU UNDERSTAND EVERYTHING?

1

● What does Lola Lago do?

● How did Lola feel that evening?

● Are Lola, Paco and Miguel like the detectives in television films?

2

Tick the correct answer:

What did Lola see from her balcony?

□ A happy couple.
□ A couple arguing.
□ A couple saying goodbye.

What does Lola do when she is very tired?

□ She falls asleep at once.
□ She reads crime novels because she cannot sleep.
□ She goes for a walk.

3 and 4

Say who did the following things: Lola, the man or the young woman?

Lola - The man - The young woman

went back out onto the balcony to water the plants.
looked nervous.
did not look like a worried lover.
went out into the street again.
returned to the square and entered the building.
came out with two suitcases and a bag.
dropped a bunch of keys.
found the keys.
went to bed.

5

- What does Lola like doing on Sunday mornings?
- What happened at number 10 on Saturday night?
- Who found Doña Lupe injured?
- Where was Doña Lupe's niece?

6 and 7

- Who were Gil and Peña?
- Do Spanish police officers like women detectives?
- Where did Doña Lupe live?
- Did Lola see the couple clearly the night before?

8

Make sentences by joining one item from each box:

a	**b**
Lola	is not interested in the case
Paco	gets angry
	rings Paco
	cannot sleep during her siesta

c	because she is thinking about what she saw the night before. because she wants to tell someone about it. because there is no “client”. because they call her “young lady”.

9

- How did Doña Elvira discover that something had happened to Doña Lupe?
- Was Doña Lupe very rich? Why?
- What do you know about María Requena, the niece?
- Who is Néstor?

10

Join the items with arrows:

Tony	is always ill.
Margarita	is Margarita's boyfriend.
Paco	is the secretary.
Miguel	eats all the time and loses everything.
Feliciano	makes many spelling mistakes.
	is very short.
	is in love with Margarita.
	is always cheerful.

12 and 13

- Who is Carmela? What does she advise Lola to do?
- How does Lola meet Néstor Requena?
- What does Lola think of Néstor?

14 and 15

True or false?

The two young women were in hospital together. □
Both young women died. □
Jenaro was the brother of one of them. □
Doña Lupe mistakes Ramona for her niece. □

16, 17 and 18

- Who rang the office?
- Why did Néstor go to the detective agency?
- What happened to his grandmother's jewellery?
- Who does Néstor think stole the jewellery?

19, 20 and 21

True or false?

□ Lola likes eating alone.
□ Ramona gave Lola Jacinta's address.
□ Lola went to see Doña Elvira very quickly.
□ Lola found something strange in María's room.
□ Néstor does not know anyone called Jenaro.
□ Lola believes in coincidences.
□ Lola likes riding on motorbikes.

22 and 23

- How did Lola get into Jacinta's old flat?
- Who was living there then?
- Did Lola find anything interesting in the flat in Calle Santa Bárbara?
- What was strange about it?

24, 25, 26 and 27

Write a short summary of Lola's two chance meetings with María. When, where and how did they happen?

28 and 29

True or false?

□ The young woman at the station was María.
□ Jacinta died at La Paz Hospital.
□ Jenaro and Jacinta wanted to inherit the grandmother's entire fortune.
□ Jenaro's father worked for the family.
□ Jacinta was Jenaro's girlfriend.

30, 31, 32 and 33

- Who was Lola meeting for dinner?
- Why do you think she had dressed so smartly?
- Who does Doña Lupe live with now?